

Hegel's Commentary on Kant's *Critique of Judgment* (*Kritik der Urteilskraft*) in
Faith and Knowledge (*Glauben und Wissen*)

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In the essay *Faith and Knowledge* (*Glauben und Wissen*), published in 1802 in the *Critical Journal of Philosophy*, Hegel presents a critical reading of Kant's philosophy by referring to it as a "philosophy of subjectivity," while simultaneously highlighting the virtue of his method and conclusions. Thus, this writing points to an attempt to go beyond Kant, yet with Kant—much like Schiller, who, in the series of letters called *Kallias-Brief* (1785–1793), attempted to establish a priori, within the transcendental realm, an objective concept of beauty. Hegel's early text, heavily oriented by Schelling's "philosophy of identity," also calls into question the limits drawn by Kant, but his "target" is philosophy in its unity—what it could be according to the speculative "vocation" of reason. The limits that Kant placed on reason in the *Critique of Pure Reason* (*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*) assume for Hegel the form of a skepticism regarding the idea of God or the Absolute—an idea that is, in his conception, the supreme idea of philosophy—because such limits are established based on the notion of the finite knowledge (*endliche Erkenntnis*) of the understanding.

In Hegel's view, in Kantian philosophy, the distinction between theoretical reason—the understanding—and practical reason resulted in the former's dominance over reason itself, such that cognition (*Erkenntnis*) is established according to the forms of the understanding; in the philosopher's words: "finitude is made absolute" (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, S. 28). This, however, is merely one way of explaining how Kant dealt with the dogmatic assertions of the metaphysics of his own time; after all, Hegel simultaneously recognized in the *Critique of Judgment* (*Kritik der Urteilskraft*) the idea of reason as the principle of reflection, and understood in the productive imagination the original unity of the faculties, as well as the absolute identity among the elements that the "division" of the understanding gave rise to. Thus, guided by this interpretation, the present work aims to show how Judgment (*Urteilskraft*) in its reflection (*Reflexion*) operates according to a transcendental principle identical in its necessity to that of reason in its natural illusions, the critique of which is undertaken by Kant in the Transcendental Dialectic. The second section will be devoted to the aforementioned comprehension of the imagination

2. The relationship between the first and third critiques.

In the opening lines of *Faith and Knowledge*, Hegel states regarding Kantian philosophy that it: “openly confesses its principle of subjectivity and formal thinking (*Denkes*) because its essence consists in being critical idealism; and in the certainty of its standpoint—that of making the unity of reflection (*Reflexion*) the highest—it reveals in the most unconcerned narrative what it is and what it wills” (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl. Bd. 62*, p. 13). Although Hegel’s statement is presented in a critical tone, the purpose of Kant’s philosophy is aptly articulated therein: to be critical idealism, which implies the acknowledgment of the limits of reason, mentioned above under the general formula of the “principle of subjectivity and formal thought.” Since the *KrV*, however, the domain of objective objective judgements has been delimited, namely, when, in the analytics of the understanding, one proceeds according to the transcendental deduction of its categories.

Just like the procedure of jurists, “to deduce” according to Kantian philosophy means to prove the legitimacy of a claim; thus, in a transcendental deduction, the way in which the pure concepts of the understanding can refer a priori and validly to objects is explained (*KrV*, AA III:100). But it must be borne in mind that the understanding always refers to nature, which is the object of possible experience. Therefore, experience itself is the “land of truth” for the understanding. And what the categories make possible is nothing other than the form of experience (*KrV*, AA IV:083); in this lies the objective validity of these concepts: they are the sole condition of possibility for experience as regards the form of thought, just as pure intuitions are in relation to the form of sensibility. Thus, one conceives of a pure I (the synthetic unity of apperception) that knows phenomena based on the formal unity of the categories.

For Hegel, this way of resolving the question of the rational (*Vernünfftige*)—which finds its highest expression in the following formulation of Kantian philosophy: “How are synthetic a priori judgments possible?”, falls into the very skepticism it sought to avoid, as the following passage announce: “Kant encountered this, which he reproached (*vorwirft*) in Hume – that is to say, that he far from thought this task of philosophy in a sufficiently determined manner and in its universality” (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl. Bd. 62*, s. 15). To put it briefly, the rational (*Vernünfftige*), or the a priori element of judgment in transcendental idealism would not have achieved “absolute identity” between

subject and object, particular and universal, but only a “relative identity” between these opposites (*Entgegengesetzten*), so that in this conception even the objectivity of the categories in experience becomes subjective, and the understanding is “the absolutely fixed, insurmountable finitude of human reason” (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, s. 23)

This objection raised by Hegel is based on the assumption that, for philosophy, “absolute identity” is “the only true reality (*Realität*),” which must be neither a matter of faith—that is, “something beyond knowledge (*Wissen*)” — nor merely knowledge itself (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, S. 14). In his view, true philosophy is knowledge (*Wissen*) of the absolute. Its task is to “resolve” the oppositions as they are found, such as spirit and world, self and nature, etc. Otherwise, it falls back, as with Kant, on the subjectivity and finitude of the understanding. That assumption, however, was never foreign to Kantian philosophy, and the question one might ask is: in what does this consist in his system – namely, in being “a beyond of knowledge” (*ein Jenseits für das Wissen*)? If it is in experience that the categories have the limit of their objectively valid use, how can human reason go beyond it? Kant assumes that reason does so, thereby falling into obscurities that arise in disputes whose arena is metaphysics (*KrV*, AA IV:007). The critique of such a use of reason, presented in the Transcendental Dialectic, warns that when reason elevates itself beyond experience, it proceeds in its inferences according to a “logic of appearance” (*logik des Scheins*), so that this “flight” of reason must be regarded as an error that “leads us (*wegführt*) entirely beyond the empirical use of the categories, deceiving us with the mirage (*Blendwerke*) of an extension of pure understanding” (*KrV*, AA III:235) —as in the proposition that the world must have a beginning in time—although he admits

Kant calls these concepts “transcendental ideas.” They are concepts of reason which, like the categories, refer to experience—albeit indirectly—and, in a manner entirely distinct from the categories, those concepts cannot find in experience their object. In brief, these ideas unify experience up to its unconditioned totality (*KrV*, AA III:251). In this sense, their pure content is the “unconditioned” (*unbedingte*). Reason thus exhibits an autonomy with respect to the objects of experience that does not exist for the understanding; reason refers only to the synthetic unity conceived in the category. And like the latter, the ideas of reason are also deduced—as occurs in the Appendix to the Transcendental Dialectic—but their validity does not depend on being the condition of possibility of an object in order to determine it; after all, these ideas are heuristic concepts

and refer, as previously stated, indirectly to the objects of experience to confer upon them the particular unity of reason. Kant illustrates this using the central idea of theology: “In such a case,” he says, “it is said that the things of the world must be regarded as if (*als ob*) they derived their existence from a supreme intelligence” (KU, V III:443). The “as if” indicates nothing more than the analogical procedure by which pure reason conceives of experience as an **imitation** of its forms. It is in this way, therefore, that the critique of transcendental ideas reaches its conclusion, assigning a regulative function to these concepts of reason.

According to Hegel’s critique, what might appear to be a solution to the issue of the ideas in the transcendental dialectic takes the form of yet another unfolding of this very same question. In its regulative use, reason is a empty unity (*leere Einheit*) (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, S. 26). Reason refers to understanding and its judgments, whereas only understanding discursively unifies the diverse into a single perception. Consequently, reason is left with nothing but the “pure emptiness of identity,” so that what it considers in judgment (*Urteil*) is the subjective or the universal purified of multiplicity, as pure and abstract unity. Now, this question would present no philosophical interest were it not driven by a necessity that will now become clearer and can be formulated as follows: how must this empty unity, as practical reason, once again become constitutive, generate itself from within (*aus sich selbst gebären*), and provide itself with content? (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, S. 27). This content is freedom, and the contradiction (*Widerspruch*) of the system, according to Hegel, consists in the fact that practical reason, while remaining in opposition to the finite, is simultaneously affirmed as autonomous. Speculative reason, which infers even transcendental ideas, from this point of view becomes even more, so to speak, “modest”; after all, in Hegel’s words: “it yields to the multiplicity of the understanding and need only regulate it; it claims neither autonomous dignity nor the self-generation of the child.” (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, S.27)

The *KU* is described as “the most interesting point of the Kantian system” (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, S. 30). Here we comprehend why the “unity of reflection” (*Einheit der Reflexion*) was conceived as “the highest point” of Kantian philosophy, as per the Hegel quote with which this topic began. Although the third critique is not described as a “region for cognition (*Erkenntnis*),” it is “a center between empirical multiplicity and absolute abstract unity” (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, S. 30). A center

between sensibility and reason. This is a “promise” that is testified to in the two introductions to the *KU*. In both texts, Kant presents the division of his philosophy based on faculties or domains (*Gebiete*) according to pure theoretical and practical principles which, as seen previously, relate respectively to nature when what is at stake is the use of the categories of understanding and to the idea of freedom in the use of pure practical reason. Indeed, in the second chapter of the second edition of the *KU*, it is stated that the idea of freedom, as the supersensible, must (*soll*) have an influence on the sensible, on nature, that is, make effective (*wirklich*) in it the end given by its laws, which assumes that there must be a foundation for the unity of both (*KU*, AA V:176). What would link these elements would be Judgment (*Urteilkraft*) itself in its reflective modality. It is by paying attention to this possibility that Hegel conceives in all the “places” of the third critique the idea of reason itself. The essential aspect of this reading is connecting judgments of reflection—namely, aesthetic judgment about beauty and theological judgment about nature—to the supersensible.

In the *KU* Introductions, Kant distinguishes between the reflecting and the determining judgment and deduces a particular principle of reflection. It is to resolve a problem of cognition (*Erkenntnis*)—one that, by the way, is initially in no way connected to beauty—whose scope is an organization of nature in the diversity of its forms, that a deduction of the principle of finality of nature (*Zweckmässigkeit der Natur*) is undertaken in the Third Critique. What is at stake here is, as in the deduction of the categories, the form of experience. However, whereas in the First Critique Kant referred to the transcendental laws of the understanding as the condition for a certain unity of the diverse—that is, as “laws for phenomena, insofar as these, linked in a consciousness, must constitute (*ausmachen*) an experience” (*KU*, AA XX:208)—in the Third Critique this legislation “cools down.” What in the *KrV* was conceived as a possible experience is now, in the *KU*, conceived as a particular or empirical experience. The former is based on the categories of the understanding, and under their laws the faculty of judgment is determinative, insofar as it merely subsumes a particular.

Kant gives us the following example of this mode of proceeding: “The understanding holds that every change has its cause (universal law of nature); the transcendental judgment has nothing more to do than to indicate a priori the conditions of subsumption under the given concept of the understanding—which is the succession of determinations of one and the same thing” (*KU*, AA V:183). Thus, judgment is

generally defined as the “faculty (*Vermögen*) of thinking the particular as contained under the universal.” It is determinative, as in the example given above, when it follows the rule of the understanding. In this case, an experience in general is also conceived. However, in empirical experience, the forms of nature may be contingent (*zufällig*) with respect to the understanding, so that here Judgment does not receive from it the rule for linking the diverse; rather, it must reflect, seeking the universal for the particular, which is not possible without a principle that judgment prescribes to itself. What is assumed in the transcendental deduction of the principle of finality in nature is that the unity of nature in an empirical experience as a system governed by laws—which are also empirical—must necessarily be presupposed and accepted as a necessity of the understanding, even though the understanding itself cannot comprehend anything of this necessity (*KU*, AA V:183). For this reason, as previously stated, the particular principle of Judgment in its reflective modality is a problem of cognition (*Erkenntnis*), although it cannot be said that a reflective judgment is determinant, and therefore objective.

There are two points that must still be very briefly considered to conclude this first moment. The first concerns whether—as the wording of the second introduction to the *KU* suggests—that unity of nature presupposed by the particular principle of Judgment is a necessity of the understanding, or else an end (*Zweck*) or even a purpose (*Absicht*), words also employed by Kant. It is pertinent to ask whether a necessity of pure reason is not surreptitiously present in such a use of the Judgment in its reflection. The second point, directly connected to the previous one, is merely a further clarification regarding the principle of finality. As for the aforementioned question, its relevance lies in the plausibility of comprehending the necessity of the principle of finality in nature as a necessity akin to that of reason, insofar as, as previously explained, reason is the seat of the “natural illusion” and its pure ideas conceive of nature—which is the object of experience—in a higher unity than that of the understanding, namely, that of a supersensible foundation. Now, this is precisely what the principle of the reflecting judgment presupposes: “that nature be represented as if (*als ob*) an understanding contained the foundation of the unity of the diverse in its empirical laws” (*KU*, AA V:181). In other words, nature is represented as art, as if the foundation of its possibility were, therefore, an end or concept of reason, so that it is also represented as “permeable” to freedom.

In the aesthetic-reflective judgment, beauty pleases (*gefällt*) through the absence of concepts, insofar as understanding is thus linked to imagination and constitutes the subjective condition of its objectivity. In place of the concept, there is only the consciousness of a formal purposiveness of a representation (*KU*, AA V:222). Hegel recognizes in this pre-conceptual moment the original unity of imagination, as a unity of faculties, in short, the pure Self that encompasses understanding and reason. With this, he presents a relationship of identity between opposites that, in a certain way, was posited in Kant's philosophy, but purified by the concepts of understanding and, in a certain sense, re-established in reflection. Thus, for Hegel, neither transcendental aesthetics nor transcendental deduction of categories can be understood in the first critique without first imagination as that from which both the subjective Self and the objective world first separate into a phenomenon. Indeed, in the *KrV*, Kant names as "productive" the imagination that has the function of linking a priori, that is, synthesizing the diverse. Although both the 1781 and 1787 editions support this thesis, in the deduction of the categories undertaken in that first edition there is more emphasis on its explanation. In this sense, Kant states: "The principle of the necessary unity of the pure (productive) synthesis of the imagination is, therefore, prior to apperception, the foundation of the possibility of all knowledge, particularly of experience" (*KrV*, AA IV:88).

With this, Hegel also evidences the productive character of the imagination and its highest function in Kant's philosophy, in his words: 'We must not, therefore, attribute Kant's merit to the fact that he placed the forms expressed in the categories into the human faculty of knowledge as the mainstay of an absolute finitude, but rather to the fact that he placed the idea of true apriority (*wahrhafter Apriorität*) more in the form of the transcendental imagination, and thereby also the beginning of the idea of reason within the understanding itself' (HEGEL, *Philos. Bibl.* Bd. 62, S. 25). Insofar as the imagination is spontaneity, it would also be an understanding that intuitively, so that in its organic unity there would be given the possibility of that unity which reason presupposes in the world in its 'natural illusion'.